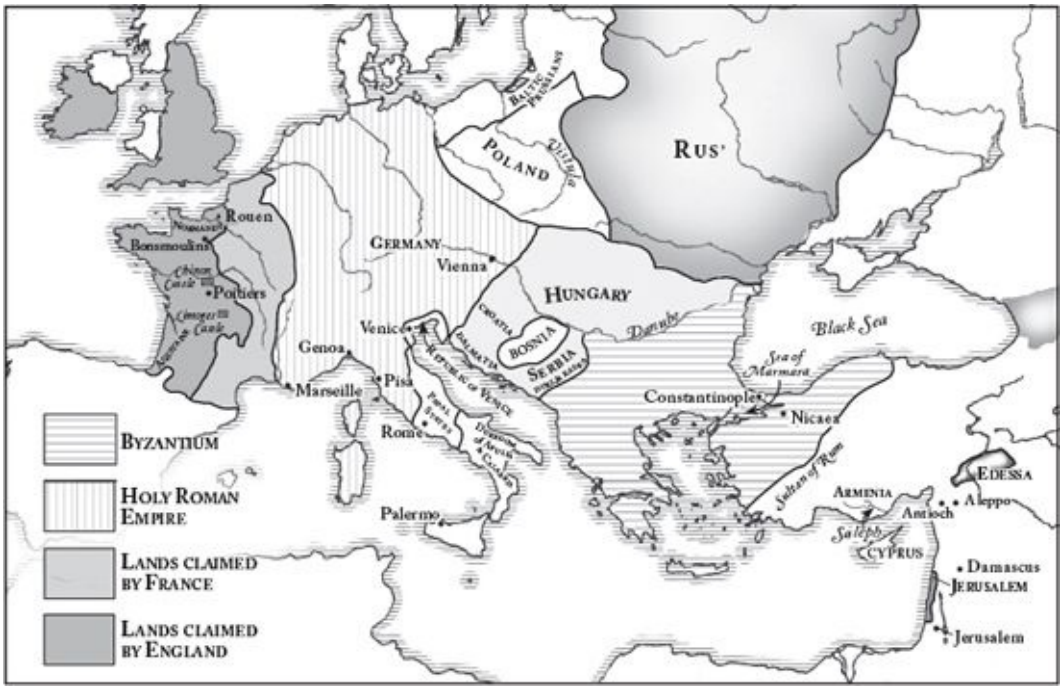
When he reached the border of the Byzantine empire, he found himself facing an unexpected enemy. Isaac Angelus, who had now been on the throne of Constantinople for four years, had originally guaranteed the Crusaders safe passage through his lands, but the approach of a huge German force supplemented with Hungarian, Bosnian, and Serbian soldiers was giving him pause. Byzantium and the Holy Roman Empire had been jostling each other for decades; he might well be giving a conquering army an open door into his empire.



24.1 The World of the Third Crusade

So he sent guerrilla bands to harass the Crusaders. “As soon as we reached the borders of our imperial brother, the emperor of Constantinople,” Frederick himself wrote, “we suffered no small loss by robbery of goods and killing of our men; and this is known without doubt to have been instigated by the emperor himself.” Vexed, he sent envoys to Constantinople to object; Angelus threw them in jail. Tensions escalated until Frederick sent a message back to his son and regent in Germany, Henry VI, asking him to get from the pope permission to declare a crusade against Byzantium so that he could attack Constantinople.[8]

At this threat, Isaac Angelus offered to let the crusading army pass, as long as it stayed south, far away from Constantinople. In the spring of 1190, Frederick Barbarossa’s army finally crossed over into Asia Minor, at the far end of the Sea of Marmara, and began a wearying march through Turkish-